

NEW BEGINNINGS

◀◀ **REWIND**



The historically frosty relations between India and the US thawed when Bill Clinton visited India on March 19, the first presidential visit in 22 years. The diplomatic call improved relations that were strained since the Cold War. Clinton, who got a rock star welcome wherever he went, pressed India to scale down its nuclear programme, sign the Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty and resolve the Kashmir issue through dialogue with Pakistan. "We want India to be strong; to be secure; to be united; to be a force for a safer, more prosperous, more democratic world," said Clinton while addressing a joint session of the Parliament.

FIRST CUT

- Mohammed Azharuddin, former captain of the Indian cricket team, became the first Indian cricketer to receive a life ban from the game for his alleged involvement in a

match-fixing deal.

- Chess grand master Viswanathan Anand beat Lithuanian Alexei Shirov to become the world champion at the FIDE World Chess Championships in Tehran.

STATE AFFAIRS

Parliament passed the Bihar Reorganisation Bill to carve 18 districts out of Bihar's eastern part to form Jharkhand, the 28th state of India. It had 14 Lok Sabha and 81 assembly seats.

◀◀ DID YOU KNOW

The population of India officially passed the 1 billion mark on May 11, when Baby Astha was born in Delhi. The UN, however, believed that India had already crossed the mark on August 15, 1999.